C2 Vocabulary

Idioms and nuance

Idiomatic expressions with subtle meanings that mark near-native fluency.

At C2 the challenge is not knowing more words but choosing the one with exactly the right shade of meaning. These idioms are frequent in journalism and conversation.

a double-edged sword idiom

something with both good and bad effects

Fame can be a double-edged sword.

to split hairs idiom

to argue about tiny, unimportant differences

Let's not split hairs over the wording.

to toe the line idiom

to follow the rules or official position

Ministers are expected to toe the party line.

a moot point idiom

something open to debate, or no longer relevant

Whether he knew is a moot point now.

to pay lip service to idiom

to say you support something without acting on it

The company only pays lip service to diversity.

the elephant in the room idiom

an obvious problem nobody mentions

The budget cut was the elephant in the room.

to have a field day idiom

to enjoy an opportunity, often to criticise

The press had a field day with the scandal.

to beg the question idiom

to make someone want to ask; also, to assume the conclusion in an argument

This begs the question of who will pay.

by the same token phrase

for the same reason

He's honest, and by the same token, rather blunt.

to throw caution to the wind idiom

to act without worrying about risks

She threw caution to the wind and quit her job.

Practice

1. The new policy says it values staff, but nothing has changed. It only ___ wellbeing.
2. Online anonymity is ___: it protects activists but also trolls.
3. Everyone knew the project was failing, but no one would mention ___.

▼ **Show answers**

1. pays lip service to
2. a double-edged sword
3. the elephant in the room